Consolidation

Securing new learning before independent practice

Use consolidation after initial explanation and guided practice to secure the new idea before increasing independence or complexity. Make students reconstruct and explain the learning.

How to do it well

1 Select the central learning. Identify the principle or process students should retain from the episode.

2 Ask for reconstruction. Use a brief explanation, completion task or related attempt that requires students to recall and organise the idea.

3 Compare thoughtfully. Let students inspect a model or another response and explain meaningful differences.

4 Repair the insecure component. Re-model a specific gap and give another fresh attempt where necessary.

5 Connect the next stage. Move into purposeful independent practice or application when sufficiently secure, and plan a later retrieval return.

What this sounds like

“Without looking at the model, explain the first decision and complete a related example. Then compare your method and identify the step you need to practise.”

Classroom example. After guided practice, pupils reconstruct the key method and complete a short related task with less visible support. Comparison with the model reveals one insecure decision, which gets a focused repair. A later retrieval return is planned. Consolidation secures the episode without being treated as proof that the learning will remain accessible permanently.

Top tips that make the technique work

Keep it focused on the new learning. A broad topic recap may miss the specific decision taught in this episode.

Require an active response. Explanation, completion or a short independent attempt shows more than rereading the model.

Use the model deliberately. Let students compare initially, then remove it for a fresh attempt.

Do not equate consolidation with easy work. Students should think about the key relationship, not merely copy a summary.

Connect to later retrieval. Consolidation helps initial security; spaced returns are still needed.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Reconstruct the important idea or process.	A final slide that students passively reread.
Use the response to decide readiness.	Assuming immediate success removes the need for later retrieval.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton — Consolidation